

General Post-Discharge Care Protocol

Universal Recovery Guidelines for All Discharged Patients | City General Hospital

1. Overview

This protocol provides universal guidance for all patients discharged from City General Hospital, regardless of diagnosis. It supplements any condition-specific instructions and covers recovery principles, medication safety, wound care, activity, nutrition, and when to seek further medical help.

Studies show 20% of patients experience a preventable adverse event within 30 days of discharge, most commonly due to medication errors, wound complications, or delayed recognition of deterioration. Adherence to these guidelines significantly reduces risk.

2. General Recovery Guidelines

- Rest adequately — aim for 8–9 hours sleep; short daytime rest is encouraged.
- Do not attempt your pre-illness activity level for at least the first 2 weeks.
- Increase activity gradually every 2–3 days; fatigue is a signal to slow down.
- Keep all follow-up appointments — missing them is the most preventable readmission cause.
- Ensure a carer or family member is aware of your discharge instructions for the first 48 hours.

3. Wound and Incision Care

Correct wound care prevents infection, promotes healing, and reduces scarring.

- Keep wound dry for 48 hours; after that, gentle showering (no soaking) is permitted.
- Do not apply creams, lotions, or herbal preparations without specific instruction.
- Change dressings as instructed using clean technique — wash hands before and after.
- Steri-Strips: leave until they fall off naturally (7–10 days); trim lifted edges only.
- Protect wound from sun for 6 months to prevent permanent hyperpigmentation.

4. Activity, Driving, and Return to Work

Driving:

- After general anaesthesia: do not drive for 24 hours minimum; longer if taking opioids.
- You must be able to perform an emergency stop without hesitation or pain.

Return to work:

- Desk work: typically 1–2 weeks after minor procedures; 2–4 weeks after major surgery.
- Manual labour: requires explicit medical clearance; may require 4–12 weeks recovery.

Exercise:

- Begin with 10 minutes walking daily in week 1; increase by 5 minutes each week.
- No swimming, gym, or contact sports until wound is healed and clearance is given.

5. Nutrition and Hydration

Good nutrition accelerates wound healing, supports immunity, and restores energy. Hospital stays often cause nutritional deficiencies due to reduced intake.

- Protein: aim for ≥ 1.2 – 1.5 g/kg body weight daily — eggs, fish, dairy, legumes.
- Hydration: drink ≥ 2 litres of water daily unless a fluid restriction has been prescribed.
- Vitamin C: citrus, bell peppers, kiwi, broccoli — essential for wound collagen synthesis.
- Iron: red meat, spinach, lentils — important after blood loss; take with vitamin C.
- Avoid alcohol entirely for 2 weeks — impairs immunity, wound healing, and medication metabolism.

6. Medication Safety at Home

Medication errors are the most common preventable cause of post-discharge harm. Know what each tablet is for, when to take it, and what to do if you miss a dose.

- Reconcile your discharge prescription with your usual medications — some may have been stopped.
- Do not take OTC medications (NSAIDs, aspirin, herbal) without checking for interactions.
- Complete the full antibiotic course even if you feel better — stopping promotes resistance.
- Store medications away from children, in a cool dry place, out of direct sunlight.

7. Warning Signs — Call 112 Immediately

- These symptoms may indicate a life-threatening complication. Act immediately — do not wait for your next appointment.
- Chest pain or tightness lasting > 5 minutes, with or without arm or jaw radiation.
- Sudden difficulty breathing at rest or inability to complete a sentence.
- Facial drooping, arm weakness, slurred speech — possible stroke.
- Loss of consciousness or collapse.
- Coughing or vomiting blood, or black tarry stools.

8. Doctor vs. Emergency — When to Call Which

Symptom / Concern	Action	Response Time
Chest pain, breathlessness, stroke signs	Call 112	Immediately
Collapse or unconsciousness	Call 112	Immediately
High fever > 39 °C	Attend emergency dept	Within 2 hours
Wound infection signs	GP / ward nurse line	Same day
Uncontrolled pain despite medication	GP / ward nurse line	Same day
Medication question or side effect	GP or pharmacist	Next opening hours
Follow-up appointment query	Outpatient department	Next working day

9. Follow-Up and Support

- Your follow-up schedule is on your discharge summary — keep this document safe.
- Missed appointments: reschedule within 24 hours; do not wait for the next routine slot.
- Bring your discharge summary, medication list, and monitoring diaries to every visit.
- Community pharmacist: no appointment needed for medication questions or interaction checks.

Patient Advice Line Mon–Fri 08:00–20:00 for non-urgent recovery queries. NHS 111 available 24/7. Synthetic document — for demonstration purposes only.